All About GNU Health

GNU Health is software that includes Electronic Medical Records (EMR), a Hospital Information System and a Health Information System. The fact that it is developed on top of the Tryton framework makes it even easier to deploy and use.

GNU Health is a complete hospital management system developed and backed by the GNU Solidario Foundation. It is platform-agnostic software built on top of Python, Tryton and the PostgreSQL database. This provides a solid foundation for the software, essentially making it easy to upgrade, vendor-independent, and of course, easy to customise according to a particular use case. Its module-based approach pertains to genetics, gynaecology, paediatrics, socio-economics, surgery, inpatient hospitalisation, laboratory reports, etc. In short, it is intended to help in managing the resources of hospitals as well as in their daily functions, by digitising all the medical processes of laboratory reports, prescriptions, medical histories, etc.

One of the features of GNU Health that you're unlikely to find in other software is the decision support system that helps while operating the software. For example, while writing prescriptions, based on the patient's medical history, it determines if the medicine prescribed is potentially risky. It will then prompt the doctors for verification, and confirm if they really want to proceed with prescribing that particular medicine. It also provides various colour-coded visual aids, which help doctors in making an informed decision regarding the health of the patient.

Features and modules

The most important features of GNU Health are listed below:

- Financial management and billing: Surprisingly, GNU Health has a list of almost all available currencies, and can do billing in any currency that you choose.
- Hospitalisation: This includes modules like admissions, appointments, bed administration, etc.
- Standardisation: GNU Health complies with WHO's ICD-10 medical standards, and contains a list of the WHO essential medicines to aid physicians, so that they can choose from a huge database of already listed diseases and medicines.
- Imaging and reports: GNU Health allows pathologists to attach various images related to the laboratory reports of the patient, like X-rays, etc, and also allows exporting them to various LibreOffice formats for external use (see Figure 1).
- Security: GNU Health's dependence on Tryton results in better security, because it uses Tryton's own security module for access control to the underlying software and data.

There are, of course, many other modules and features (Figure 2) and this is not an exhaustive list; rather, just an overview of the software's capabilities.

Installing and configuring

Since GNU Health is broadly dependent on the following software, we need to install them before we proceed further: